Non-Aligned Movement (it cooperated closely with India[64] in order to set this up as a formal organisation). Burma also was a member of the United Nations and its broadly neutral stance (between the Soviets and Americans) meant that U Thant was elected secretary-general of the UN in 1961.[65] Burma was to remain a member of the Non-Aligned Movement up to 1979 and has maintained its UN membership, despite being regularly criticised for human rights abuses.

Although after 1962 the military regime formally claimed it was socialist, it had little contact with the USSR, the People's Republic of China[66] or the later socialist regimes in Vietnam and Cambodia (beyond some arms sales), and it attempted to keep neutral in the Sino–Soviet split. In effect, a pattern of limited international interest in Burma's affairs was established, apart from the interest that some logging and mining companies took (they generally found it easy to accommodate the regime's 'eccentricities').

The military came to believe that Myanmar faced a unique set of development challenges and that there was little for it to gain from close involvement with the outside world.[67] However, the reality was that the regime was less isolationist than is sometimes believed. They embraced a very practical approach to international relations, less in terms of alliances and more in terms of pragmatic exchanges to gain something they sought or to sell commodities they were able to extract from provinces they controlled. Their foreign policy was framed by a mindset that saw any external pressure as illegitimate and intrusive, but equally the successive regimes knew that in order to realise the wealth of Myanmar (even if only for their own enrichment), they needed a degree of international interaction. However, they managed to ignore international pressure over human rights.[68]

At the regional level, the period after 1950 also saw difficult relations with the neighbouring powers of Malaysia, Thailand and East Pakistan/Bangladesh—usually fuelled by tensions arising from border disputes between the Burmese government and various tribal communities with links to those neighbouring countries. Burma's participation in regional groupings such as ASEAN was partial as regional tensions reduced the scope for practical cooperation.